

Clashed

Love?

Written by

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INT. LIVING ROOM, 149/E, BADARPUR, NEW DELHI - AFTERNOON- APRIL 25

A door creaks open. In walks ADITHYA (17, Indian, student - Grade 12, nicknamed Appu), still in his school uniform. He throws his backpack onto the sofa, barely missing the small coffee table in front of it. Right across, the TV sits, switched off. He plops down onto the sofa, stretching out like he's melting into it. To his left, an open kitchen blends into the living space.

ADITHYA

(loud, exhausted, half-groaning)

Mom, what's there for lunch? I am starving!

A lady can now be spotted from the room, working in the kitchen. Mother (39, Indian, Homemaker) can be seen cooking something on the gas stove. She is dressed in a suit-salwar - Indian clothing.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(without looking, playful but dry)

Is that the Gen-Z method of saying you're home now, Appu?

ADITHYA

(grumbling, under his breath)

Not again...

MOTHER walks in, setting a plate of rice with paneer gravy on the coffee table. Not his favorite, but decent. She sits beside him, dusting her hands on her dupatta.

MOTHER

You're not touching lunch until you change and freshen up. You wouldn't have been acting this way had your dad been here, would you?

ADITHYA

(mutters, walking offscreen)

Yeah, yeah...

ADITHYA groans but drags himself offscreen. A few moments later, he reappears in a loose T-shirt and shorts, hair still messy and uncombed. The TV is on now, playing the news—something about space. His eyes light up.

ADITHYA

(suddenly alert, pointing at the screen)

Hey, that's Neil deGrasse Tyson! Arjun and I binge-watch his space videos all the time.

MOTHER

(not really interested)

Ah, yes. You two space folks, your food is getting cold here, back on Earth.

Adithya doesn't seem too bothered by his mother's comment. His exhaustion vanishes. He nearly jumps onto the sofa, eyes glued to the TV.

MOTHER

At least look at your plate while eating.

Adithya doesn't pay much heed to his mother's command, and she lets it go—for now. She finishes her lunch in 5 minutes, getting up only to notice that he has barely eaten anything. She is used to it now, and just walks away offscreen to the kitchen.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(sighs, watching him, then shakes her head with a half-smile)

One day, you'll forget to breathe watching this space stuff.

Right about now, the introductions to Neil (and some other of his colleagues) have been finished and the event is about to start - something about some info that'll later be released by NASA as an

official press release about some space event.

TV ANCHOR

(to Neil)

So, what's this space event you mentioned about which the press release will be released by NASA?

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

(calm intellectual tone)

My colleagues and I have found some unusual activity in the cosmos. There is a good and a bad news.

TV ANCHOR

(formal tone with a slight humor)

Let's hear the good news first – keep us smiling, Neil.

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

The multiverse theory we've been working on is true. It works.

ADITHYA

(jolly, excited)

I knew it, I knew it... Those fools in my club making fun of the multiverse theory. I'll show them now.

TV ANCHOR

(amazed)

Wow, that's an impressive step, folks, we've taken the first step in understanding the configuration of the universe.

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

(serious, slightly hesitant)

But the bad news... We're not alone

(pauses, locking eyes with the camera)

And no universe is ever meant to collide with another... But ours is.

ADITHYA

(frowning his brows, trying to make sense of it)

Wait... but that shouldn't even be possible. Universes exist in different dimensions, completely separate from each other. A collision shouldn't affect us... at most, we might catch glimpses of something – but nothing major, right?

The TV anchor stiffens, the edges of his triumphant smile twitching downward. He nods slowly, pretending to absorb Neil's words—but his unfocused eyes betray him. His knowledge is thin, and his shock is thick. Even the scientist notices that.

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

(chuckling)

I see you're having trouble. Don't worry—it's not a catastrophe. At least, as far as our simulations worked.

ADITHYA

(amused, barely paying attention to the concern in Neil's voice)

"Well, would you look at that—two correct deductions in one day. That's got to be a record."

(shrugs, still grinning)

TV ANCHOR

Don't scare us, Neil. So, what will happen?

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

As far as our equations are, if the colliding universe is from a very close branch as our universe in the grand chart of parallel universe bifurcations, only few of us would see any difference. We might see and hear a few things for as long as the collision occurs, which should be about a few days or weeks.

(matter-of-factly tone)

It very well might just be the universes passing right through each other with no impact at all.

TV ANCHOR

(pauses, voice dropping slightly)

And... if it's not from a close branch? Are we in danger?

NEIL DEGRASSE TYSON

(exhales, thinking)

Truth is... we don't know. We still barely understand how our own universe behaves—let alone another colliding into it.

Just then, there's a blip sound from the on-screen monitor as NASA finally publishes the official press release of the upcoming occurrence.

Adithya exhales sharply, shaking his head as the anchor keeps talking. He picks up the remote and flicks off the TV mid-sentence.

ADITHYA

(muttering, unimpressed, but excited)

They'll make a circus out of this.

Without a second glance at the screen, he gets up, pacing across the living room. His half-eaten lunch sits forgotten as he strides toward his room—ignoring the media's circus. He needs real data. He needs NASA's document.

His phone buzzes. For a split second, he thinks—maybe it's her. But it's just a news update. "NASA confirms upcoming cosmic event—What does this mean for us?" He snorts, shaking his head. If only figuring out love was as easy as physics.

FADE OUT.

**INT. ADITHYA'S ROOM, 149/E, BADARPUR, NEW DELHI - EVENING
-APRIL 25 (SAME DAY)**

A modest room, one wall lined with a tall bookshelf packed with books from top to bottom. Another wall is covered with his printed poems, some taped, others boldly scrawled in permanent marker. Opposite it,

a medium-sized desk holds his laptop, where Adithya sits, browsing through the NASA press release. His phone rests face-up beside him, its dark screen reflecting the glow of the screen. The room is spacious but lacks a bed, leaving the open floor untouched.

Adithya leans forward slightly, scrolling through the document, his fingers drumming absently against the wooden desk. His brows knit together, eyes scanning the text with quiet focus.

Just as he smirks at something strange in the NASA Press Release, he hears a voice calling out to him from the living room.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(sarcastic)

Will you come in here for a moment, Appu?

ADITHYA

(muttering under breath)

Why can't they let me work?

He nudges his desk forward, sighing as he rises from his chair. With a reluctant stretch, he heads offscreen to the living room.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(as his footsteps fade out)

Care to explain why half of your lunch is here?

ADITHYA (O.S.)

(hesitant, realizing his mistake)

Uh... I was totally about to eat that.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(deadpan)

Yeah? Go feed it to the dogs.

(sighs, shaking her head)

And you better wash your plates. Forget it – I'll do it myself. Just go.

Adithya's footsteps fade in as the door creaks open. He sinks into his chair, nudging the table forward, eyes already locked back on the NASA press release.

ADITHYA

(cracking his fingers)

Now, where was I?

(focused completely on a single line of the document)

Huh... that doesn't add up. How did NASA even predict this? No theory can pinpoint another universe's position, let alone a collision...

He flips back a few pages, scanning the data, fingers tapping absently against the desk.

ADITHYA

(muttering, realization creeping in)

Unless...

His breath quickens. He yanks open a drawer, grabs a rough notebook, and starts scribbling—breaking down the anomaly in NASA's findings.

ADITHYA

(mumbling to himself, excitedly)

Of course! No theory so far can map a parallel universe—we don't even know how to define the 'space' between them. So how did NASA predict a collision?

It could be a bluff... but their data checks out. Which means—

(pauses, scanning his calculations)

They're not going to collide...

(beat, double-checking, swallowing hard)

They already have. We're in the middle of it.

Adithya pulls out his phone, opens WhatsApp, and clicks on the most recent chat - Aryan, his best friend.

ADITHYA

(texting to Aryan)

Meet me at HIS apartment in 10 to 20 mins. If you don't want to miss out on something great, that is.

Adithya stands up, nudging the table back. He swaps his shorts for joggers. As he packs his notebook, laptop, and pen, his fingers brush against a small keychain – something he bought for her, but didn't have the courage to do so. He exhales, tucking it back in without a second thought. Maybe later. He walks offscreen, the door creaking open, to go to HIS apartment. And is seen by Mother just as he is about to leave the house.

MOTHER (O.S.)

Where are you going, smarty-pants?

ADITHYA (O.S.)

Rahul's apartment.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(placing her hand on her temples)

He's older than you. Show some respect.

(commanding tone)

And you should be home by 7:30.

The house outer door is heard opening, as Adithya leaves for Rahul's apartment.

FADE OUT.

INT. LIVING ROOM (RAHUL'S APARTMENT), 160/J, BADARPUR, NEW DELHI -APRIL 25 (LATER)

A small, cramped space, barely enough for one, let alone three. Books spill from overstuffed shelves onto the floor, table, even the kitchen counter. A whiteboard leans against the wall, covered in

half-finished equations and stray notes.

On the desk, a laptop hums—half-screen code, half chemistry notes. Beside it, a half-eaten Maggi bowl and an abandoned coffee mug, long gone cold.

The tiny open kitchen is a mess—spice bottles scattered, a single plate with crumbs by the sink, just enough space for a gas stove.

The air lingers with old books, instant noodles, and stale coffee. A standing fan hums, pushing warm air. One bulb's been fused for weeks, but Rahul hasn't bothered.

A knock on the door. Rahul drags himself to the door, pulling it open.

ADITHYA

(from the door)

Yo, it's me.

(door opens)

How ya doin'?

RAHUL

(exhausted)

Dragging by. Where's Aryan?

Rahul moves to the side, letting Adithya in.

ADITHYA

(facepalming at the mess)

He'll be dropping here soon. Read the NASA press release?

Adithya doesn't bother asking about the mess. It's a common thing now.

RAHUL

(shocked)

NASA made a press release?

Rahul pulls out his phone, scrolling fast. He didn't read the actual information, but just checked for notifications.

RAHUL

(groaning)

Damn it. Must've been during class—cleared my notifications without checking.

Rahul's phone rings - he just declines. Adithya notices "Dad" on the phone, wondering why he'd decline his father's call, but doesn't intrude to ask why.

RAHUL

(excited, eager)

So, what was it about?

ADITHYA

Collision of our universe with another parallel one.

RAHUL

(skeptical)

Right. And next, you'll tell me the moon's crashing into us too.

ADITHYA

(smirking)

Actually? They said it could happen anytime. Any moment.

RAHUL

(still refusing to believe)

Stop joking around. Anyhow it's not like it's too much to be afraid about. Most likely, the two universes would just pass through each other. We've already gone over this in our imaginary events. You came all over here just for that?

ADITHYA

(leaning in, smug)

NASA's bluffing. And my numbers prove it.

RAHUL

(shocked)

Are you for real? You expect me to believe your calculations more than NASA's?

ADITHYA

They say, equations speak louder than words, don't they?

RAHUL

(deadpan)

No, they don't! It's "actions speak louder than words".

Adithya stays quiet, shoves some books aside, and drops onto the floor. As he pulls out his laptop, a keychain slips out with it. Rahul notices.

RAHUL

(sighing)

Still clinging onto it, huh? Just give it and be over with it, idiot!

A knock interrupts their conversation, not that Adithya wanted to reply about that. He immediately put back the keychain inside his bag, taking out his rough notebook as well.

ADITHYA

I'll open it. Probably Aryan.

Adithya hands him the laptop, after opening the NASA press release on it, as he reads through it. Adithya gets up and paces over to the door, pulling it open, as a slightly healthy boy - Aryan comes into view.

ARYAN

How many times do I have to tell you? You can't just text 'SHOW UP' and expect me to drop everything!

ADITHYA

(grinning, shaking his head)

And you wonder why you're single.

ARYAN

Says the guy with the keychain still in his bag? Right, Rahul?

ADITHYA

She tied me a Rakhi, man. What am I supposed to do?

Rahul exhaled quietly, eyes locked on the document—reading with even more focus than before. Aryan shrugged. Silence. He walked over across the room, noticing something written on the whiteboard.

He reads it aloud.

ARYAN

(reading)

Mr. Sharma is a K-NH₂.

(groaning)

Isn't that too old a pun, Rahul? Hardly funny these days.

They all got it instantly – too basic to miss. '-NH₂' reads as 'amine,' and 'K-NH₂' sounds just enough like 'ka-amine'—which, in Hindi, isn't exactly polite. A joke every noob thinks they've invented first.

RAHUL

(confused)

Oh, some of my friends had dropped over. They might've written it.

Aryan glances around the room, unbothered by why he was summoned. He knows Rahul is working on it, and Aryan's job anyhow comes into play when it's rigorous mathematics.

Adithya settles onto the floor beside Rahul, lost in Rakshabandhan nostalgia.

A good half an hour passes.

RAHUL

(confused)

Hey, the press release looks all good and perfect to me.

No reply. Adithya is still lost in his world of that day when he was tied the Rakhi by her. Too lost to hear. Until he gets a smack on his head by Aryan.

ADITHYA

(sitting up straighter, clearing his throat)

Right. Where were we?

Did you finish reading it?

RAHUL

Yeah, and I don't see any problem.

Adithya takes back his laptop, scrolling to the line that caught his attention.

ADITHYA

Read it, will you?

(proceeding to read himself)

"Current models lack the capability to determine, even roughly, the distance or relative position of the potential colliding universe."

(looking between them)

You're telling me you still don't see the problem?

Aryan and Rahul look at each other, confused at what the problem is.

ARYAN

(leaning back, smirking)

Look, Mr. Space Guy, are you gonna enlighten us, or should we beg Your Majesty for the royal explanation?

ADITHYA

(rolling his eyes, smirking)

Let me dumb it down for the two of you poor folks.

(a slightly serious explanation)

If NASA has no ways of mapping the distance between two universes, which is a right claim as I checked out every science journal, how did it even figure out its trajectory or figure out it's going to collide? And the release doesn't even hint at how they figured it out.

RAHUL

(finally getting it)

So the collision's already happening – it's in progress as we speak, right? You ran the numbers?

ARYAN

(excited)

Of course he did. That's why he summoned us.

I nod, pulling out my rough notebook, flipping to the calculations—built on principles Aryan and I had theorized, mixed with some universally accepted ones.

ADITHYA

(excited)

The math checks out – the two universes are barely apart, off by maybe an order of 1 or even less. And get this... for over a week, they'll be phasing right through each other. A perfect overlap. Every place, every structure... even the people. Synced.

RAHUL

Ah, and it'd stay locked for a while – it stabilizes the parallel universes when treated as a system.

ARYAN

(connecting the dots)

So, every particle exists in both the universes at the same time...

ADITHYA

(ominous)

Probably.

ADITHYA

(loving their excited reactions)

Yup. Aryan, check the calculations – especially my vector analysis. See if anything feels off.

Aryan strokes his beard, eyes narrowing – either questioning why NASA would even hide this or already running the math in his head.

Aryan and Rahul double-check the math, scanning for errors.

Minutes slip by.

Adithya's eyes accidentally fall on the clock. 7:40.

ADITHYA

(alarmed)

Holy cow! It's 7 40 already?

ARYAN

(glancing at his watch, groaning)

Crap. I was supposed to be home at 7:15.

They scramble up, grabbing their bags. Aryan bumps into the table, knocking over a book.

ADITHYA

(rushing to the door)

Rahul, think you can run a simulation? Map out the first day of the overlap – use your college's supercomputer if you have to.

RAHUL

(looking at the schedule)

Yeah, my laptop can't handle something this big. I'll text you when it's done, but expect a 3-4 day delay – professors have the supercomputer tied up.

ARYAN

That's good enough.

(turning to Adithya)

Send me your rough calculations over WhatsApp once you reach home... I'll have my dad look over them.

ADITHYA

(joyful, to Aryan)

Sure, now, I should rush. You coming as well, right?

The two exit the apartment walking offscreen.

Rahul pulls out his phone again, his fingers hovering over his Dad's WhatsApp profile. But he closes the app and gets back to working on the college assignment.

FADE OUT.

INT. SECTION S1, GRADE 12, XYZ SCHOOL, FARIDABAD, HARYANA - MORNING -APRIL 26 (NEXT DAY)

The classroom hums with activity, though the crowd is thinner with the festival approaching. At the front, a fresh blackboard and a teacher's desk stand ready. Lectures haven't begun, so students mill about. Aryan steps in, scanning the room. The moment he spots Adithya, he walks straight toward him.

ARYAN

(voice barely above a whisper, eyes downcast)

He's gone, man... Rahul's dad.

ADITHYA

What—? When? We saw Rahul last night—he didn't say a word.

ARYAN

He was supposed to go home yesterday...

(pauses, swallows hard)

But since we stopped by, he stayed back.

(a beat, hands tightening into fists)

Around 9, his dad left home to pick him up... but never made it. I didn't find out until this morning

A heavy silence lingers between them—neither sure what to say, both facing a conversation they've never had before.

ADITHYA

(staring at Aryan, at a loss for words)

Goddamn it...

(inhales sharply, rubs his face, shakes his head)

So where is he? Rahul, I mean.

ARYAN

(looking at the rest of the class)

He's at the hospital. We should go after school.

ADITHYA

We should go now.

ARYAN

(exhales, voice low, barely amused)

Yeah, because my dad owns the school, right? I can come and go whenever I want...

(shakes head slightly, eyes distant)

Look, we should just wait...

ADITHYA

(sharp glare, dead serious)

We should go now.

ARYAN

(hesitates, glancing around, then sighs)

How? Fake being sick?

ADITHYA

(dryly, unimpressed)

Yeah. Real simple.

ARYAN

(rolls his eyes)

It's not going to work.

(exhales, uneasy)

Anyhow, my dad's there with him. He asked me not to worry.

(turns to look at Adithya)

So, all we should do right now is wait for school to end, clear?

Not able to find any flaw in the plan, Adithya looks away in angered grief.

ADITHYA

(muttering, frustrated)

First the collision, and now this... what the hell's wrong with the universe?

Something stirs in Aryan. He hesitates, reading the room, measuring the weight of the moment.

He exhales, trying to calm himself down before he finally manages to speak.

ARYAN

(calm, serious)

The collision is about 6 to 7 months away. We'll need the simulation for precise timing, but my rough estimate from last night puts it in that range.

ADITHYA

(detached, hardly interested)

Oh, thanks.

(gulps)

Rahul's dad died, right? So... there must be some other universe where he's still alive. Where we never stopped by, where Rahul made it home on time, where his dad is...

Aryan's fingers twitch – like he wants to say something, but the words never come. Instead, he just got up and walked out, slipping past the door and exiting offscreen.

The chatter and laughter fade into the background.

A student passed, fist-bumping Adithya. He returned it instinctively, without looking up.

Just before the lecture began, an announcement echoed through the room.

TEACHER 1

Due to low attendance, Sections S1 and S2 will be merged – same for C1 and C2. Both will follow the S1 and C1 schedules, respectively.

ADITHYA

(muttering to himself)

Yeah, leave it to the school to make a bad day worse.

(cracking his fingers, tapping a foot impatiently)

I guess all I can do is just wait.

A few minutes later, S2 students trickle in – Aryan slips in with them, drying his hands with a handkerchief.

Adithya doesn't really know all the students of S2 by names, but he recognizes a few.

He spots a familiar girl settling into the seat in front of him. He glances at Aryan, catching the faint blush creeping in. He exhales, debating for a second, then leans in as Aryan comes to sit down right next to Adithya.

ADITHYA

(whispering, dry, forced smirk)

Looks like we've got Miss Nature for company. Perfect timing!

ARYAN

(glares at him)

Seems like a good time to flirt, doesn't it?

ADITHYA

(crossing his hands, slightly aloud)

Look, I don't want to sound mad, but you're the one who said all we can do is wait.

ARYAN

(louder, turning a few heads)

That doesn't mean flirting.

(a beat, exhales, rubbing his temples, voice dropping)

Just - don't act like nothing happened.

Just before the first class started, Adithya slipped out of the classroom, and never returned to the class the whole day.

After school, when Aryan finally made it to the hospital, he found Adithya already there—sitting next to Rahul, quietly listening to Aryan's dad.

FADE OUT.

**INT. SECTION S1, GRADE 12, XYZ SCHOOL, FARIDABAD, HARYANA -
NOON -APRIL 28 (TWO DAYS LATER)**

Aryan and Adithya sit in their usual seats, the classroom now merged once again with S2. Their homeroom teacher sits at her desk,

overseeing the scattered conversations and lunch breaks.

The tension that once lingered between Aryan and Adithya seems to have faded—or at least, that's how it looks.

ARYAN

(casually)

Rahul texted my dad yesterday.

ADITHYA

Not you? That's weird.

ARYAN

He wants us there after school—looks like he cracked the simulation.

ADITHYA

(excited but confused)

Didn't he say there'd be a 3 to 4-day delay? And why text your dad?

ARYAN

(confused himself, shrugs)

Who knows? Looks like he worked overnight to fit into the supercomputer's tight schedule.

ADITHYA

(even more confused)

That doesn't seem like him at all.

Amidst the exchange, Aryan spots a girl coming towards him. Or rather, towards Adithya.

ADITHYA

(continuing without noticing)

He left me on 'read' - didn't even bother to reply -

ARYAN

(interrupting, whisper)

She is coming.

At the word, Adithya turns around, to find Sakshi standing right behind him - the girl who had tied him the rakhi.

ADITHYA

(faster beats, slight blush)

Hi. What happened?

ARYAN

(smirking, overly formal)

If you don't mind, your loyal servant and I were in the middle of something. So, it'd help if you hurry up.

ADITHYA

(biting his anger at Aryan's interruption)

Don't worry about him.

(politely)

What happened?

SAKSHI

(sweet voice)

Could you let the bus driver know I won't be taking the bus this afternoon?

ADITHYA

(slightly disappointed, but hiding it)

Your dad's coming to pick -

(pausing mid-statement)

Oh, that's none of my business. Cool, I'll tell him.

(forced chuckle)

It just means more space in the bus...

SAKSHI

(confused)

Thanks... I guess.

(to Aryan)

And he's not my servant. Just a friend.

ARYAN

(snapping right back)

Yeah, or as some call it - bro-zoned.

Sakshi seems to have not heard it. She walks away to her friends circle.

ARYAN

(louder, making sure she hears)

Same thing as 'servant,' you know...

She doesn't turn back. Doesn't acknowledge it.

Aryan scoffs, shaking his head as he turns to Adithya.

ARYAN

(not bothering to lower his voice)

She's a witch, I tell you. Plays the tough game.

ADITHYA

(hushed firm)

She's not a witch.

ARYAN

(rolling his eyes)

And you, my best friend...

(sigh, then smirk)

You're such a loyal slave.

The school classes breeze through, Adithya drifting into daze - while accidentally staring at Sakshi - a few times, before being slapped awake by Aryan.

FADE OUT.

INT. LIVING ROOM (RAHUL'S APARTMENT), 160/J, BADARPUR, NEW DELHI - EVENING - APRIL 28 (SAME DAY)

The room is worse than before—coffee cups everywhere, empty Maggi bowls stacked on the table. The laptop teeters at the edge, somehow defying gravity.

At the whiteboard, Rahul scribbles equations, dark circles carved under his eyes. Judging by the mess, he hasn't slept in days.

The front door reads: "DON'T COME IN."

A firm knock is heard as Rahul drags himself towards the door, opening it. There stand Aryan and Adithya.

RAHUL

(voice rough, barely standing straight)

Come in, come in.

The two see the entire mess. They expected messy – but not this.

ARYAN

(taken aback)

What have you done to yourself?

RAHUL

(forced chuckle, waving it off)

This? It's normal. College life. Sleepless nights, bad eating, the works. You'll get used to it.

ADITHYA

(shocked, alarmed)

I don't see any of your friends looking half-dead.

Rahul doesn't even bother reacting to Adithya's comment, almost as if he didn't hear it.

RAHUL

(hoarse voice, rough)

Come on, I'll show the simulation. I managed to book the supercomputer for an hour.

There is no excitement in their pace. Even they're dragging themselves now, their excitement fading into worry.

ADITHYA

(feigning excitement)

Did it work? Was my hypothesis right?

No reply.

ARYAN

(thinking Rahul didn't hear it)

So, the calculations are wrong?

RAHUL

(slightly joyful tone)

No, they're perfect. Just perfect.

ARYAN

(whispering just to Adithya)

Hey, why is he ignoring you?

ADITHYA

(confused himself, whispering back)

How should I know? Maybe he didn't catch it.

The three exit offscreen, heading to the college campus.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMPUTER SCIENCE LAB, B2A, IIT DELHI, NEW DELHI - LATE EVENING -APRIL 28 (SAME DAY)

Rows upon rows of PCs stretch across the massive lab—at least a hundred in total. Even at this hour, the place hums with activity. Some students work on coursework, others on projects, heads buried in screens.

Rahul, Aryan, and Adithya step in, barely earning a glance.

RAHUL

(low, directed at Aryan)

Find seats where it's quieter.

Aryan and Adithya weave through the crowd, settling in a quieter corner. Rahul steps away to get permission from the lab manager.

ARYAN

(low toned whispers)

He's still ignoring you.

ADITHYA

(exhaling shaking head)

Whatever I did, he could at least tell me.

Aryan simply shrugs.

Minutes pass in heavy silence.

Rahul returns, slipping into a seat beside Aryan. He pulls out a pen drive, plugging it in, loading up his simulation in one of the PCs.

The way Rahul moved — like something inside him had already given up — left them silent. Any words of concern died in their throats."

RAHUL

(turning to Aryan while the simulation loads)

I found two things in the last few days. First, the perfect overlap will happen in 6 months and 13 days from now, meaning October 27, and will last for about 2 to 3 weeks.

Rahul coughs. Uncontrollably. Eyes turn toward him, and one of his friends nearby grabs his arm, steadying him before leading him offscreen to the restroom.

Ten minutes crawl by, thick with silence. The simulation finally finishes loading, but neither of them feels at ease.

Rahul returns, looking slightly better – but it's all surface. The exhaustion, the emptiness, still lingers in his eyes. He slips into his chair, and requests access for the supercomputer using his password in PowerShell.

ARYAN

(faking indifference)

So, what was the second thing?

Adithya keeps quiet, realizing that he has been given the signal of being ignored. He just listens.

RAHUL

(smiling weakly)

NASA wasn't bluffing.

ARYAN

(taken aback)

Huh? But you said Adithya's hypothesis was perfect.

(trying to make some sense)

That only means that NASA was bluffing.

Rahul pulls out his phone, loading the NASA Press Release, handing it to Aryan as he continues pushing himself to work on the starting of simulation.

RAHUL

(focused on the PC screen)

Load to the bottom.

Aryan loads to the bottom to find contact information in case of reporting error, submitting complaints or asking doubts. Interestingly, the e-mail provided wasn't an official one, like `kelly.l.garcia@nasa.gov`, but instead a private one, `wethenasa@gmail.com`.

RAHUL

Your friends sent it to me, wondering if we should report the collision error to NASA.

Both Aryan and Adithya noticed the way he referred to the latter. But they thought of ignoring it anyhow.

RAHUL

(taking slow, pained breaths)

NASA has never put such a thing ever in its documents. I checked every single one.

Something clicks instantly in Adithya's mind, making him forget that he was being ignored.

Adithya's gaze sharpens, reading over the email again. A private email, not a formal one. Not meant for the media. Meant for...

ADITHYA

(excited)

Meaning it's attempted at attracting the scientific minds to solve the problem.

No reply. Rahul is still fighting off errors, trying to stabilize the simulation.

ARYAN

(used to the ignoring by now, processing)

So they left the mistake in on purpose— as bait. And the private mail as a hint.

(beat, realization deepens)

The media wouldn't notice. They're too busy screaming about the collision.

(pauses, frowning, voice lower)

But why? NASA has direct access to the top scientists in the world. Why not just summon them?

Adithya's lips part slightly – then press shut. Enough of being ignored.

RAHUL

(flat, rasping)

You overthink the obvious, Aryan.

(coughs once)

NASA doesn't want their funders to find out that it's desperate.

Silence. Aryan's mind races as he searches on Rahul's phone for NASA's funders.

ARYAN

(fast scrolling)

Makes sense. Most of those fat pigs investing have recently been shifting their money toward private enterprises.

Rahul nods absently. Adithya lowers his head onto the desk—silent, shut out.

A few moments drag by.

RAHUL

(sits back, rubbing his temples, voice dull)

Alright... Let's just run it.

The simulation loads into the supercomputer. The parallel universe appears overstuffed, tangled—chaotic. Not the clean, structured world they expected. It doesn't make sense; the universes differ by less than an order of one.

And, it moves fast. Too fast. Accelerating rapidly.

Rahul's exhaustion lingers, but something shifts. A flicker of focus. A trace of urgency.

Rahul scrubs past the early parts of the simulation, skipping ahead to October 18, 7:00 PM.

The overlap barely lasts a second before the parallel universe swings away—then snaps back. It keeps oscillating, like a pendulum, tethered to the overlap position. But the oscillations aren't slow — they're near-instant. The speeds are so massive that it almost disappears from one extreme and reappears at the other, flickering in and out like a glitch.

Rahul pauses the simulation. Slowly, he turns—not to Adithya, but to Aryan.

RAHUL

(piecing it together)

Now, this didn't happen when I ran a low-quality simulation on my 32GB RAM laptop. It just showed the parallel universe decelerating - without any flicks or oscillations.

ARYAN

(thinking ahead)

Makes sense. But for the oscillations to stop on October 27, there has to be a damping force at play.

Rahul scrubs ahead to October 27.

The oscillations have almost vanished—no more violent swings, no rapid flickers. What remains is a faint, near-imperceptible tremor, so minimal that the supercomputer barely registers it.

Rahul pauses at the exact moment the oscillations fully stabilize.

ARYAN

(leaning in)

Okay, so your estimation was right... Now we just need to figure out why it's so much more chaotic than our universe.

The two zoom into the parallel universe, hiding their own.

To say it's abnormal is an understatement—it looks like an infant went wild with paint, smearing colors without reason, without form.

A faint spark flickers in Adithya's eyes—neither of them notices. Aryan, lost in his own wonder, forgets Adithya is even there.

Adithya rises from his chair – still unnoticed – and moves away, settling next to the guy who had helped Rahul when he was coughing, a noticeable distance from the two.

The guy doesn't mind Adithya seeing him work.

ADITHYA

(curious, low-voice)

What are you doing, bhaiya?

SUNIL

(small smile)

It's an assignment task. Something about sorting numbers in an array the most efficient way.

ADITHYA

(shrugging, almost self-conscious)

Oh. I solved it when I started programming a year back. But it was clunky and slow – nowhere near efficient.

Sunil politely nods - much better than Rahul's ignoring.

SUNIL

(trying to small-talk)

So, what are you two and Rahul trying to do? He never brings accomplices to the lab...

Adithya involuntarily twitches at Rahul's name.

ADITHYA

(waving it off)

It's really nothing. Feels like he only brought me here to ignore me.

(exhaling)

It was my idea, and now I'm the one being shut out.

(faking excitement)

What you're doing is far more interesting, bhaiya!

SUNIL

(chuckling slightly)

Really! You flatter me.

(knowingly)

You're telling me sorting numbers is more interesting than a whole universe colliding?

ADITHYA

(taken aback)

How- How did you know?

SUNIL

Rahul used to talk about you two a lot - always called you pure geniuses.

(pauses, hesitant)

I don't know what changed after, well...

(avoiding mentioning)

Whatever happened, it must've hit him hard. Maybe that's why he's avoiding you.

Adithya stays quiet, too drained to argue. Sunil glances at him, then pats his back.

SUNIL

(grinning)

Don't sulk, chhote. Things will fall back in place.

(playfully, reassuring)

And if they don't, I'll knock some sense into Rahul myself.

Adithya chuckles slightly, his mood lifting just a little.

He notices the two still bent over the simulation, deep in thought.
Sunil follows his gaze.

SUNIL

(amused, knowingly)

You already know the answer they're looking for, don't you?

ADITHYA

(smirks, stretching slightly)

Oh, I do... And they've been going in circles for minutes.

(uplifted tone)

Guess it's time for Cosmologist Adithya to make an appearance.

Sunil watches, impressed by how fast Adithya's mood shifts.

SUNIL

(chuckling)

Yeah, we need you, champ!

ADITHYA

(grinning, rolling his shoulders)

Might as well keep talking until Rahul snaps and tells me why he's pissed.

SUNIL

(laughing, shaking his head)

That's one way to do it.

Sunil chuckles at Adithya's antics, turning back to his work as
Adithya slips right back next to Aryan and Rahul.

RAHUL

(bitter, without looking up)

Guess who's back... Mr. Over-smart!

(flat voice, like he's holding something back)

Rahul's tone is sharp, almost as if he hates Adithya.

ADITHYA

(pointing at Rahul)

And you, my dear friend, are ignored.

(looking at the paused screen)

Ask the simulating app to zoom into Earth's orbit in the parallel universe.

Rahul shrugs indifferently, but not having his own solutions follows Adithya's lead.

ADITHYA

(smug tone)

Now, hide the trajectory of everything including Earth's. Hide the stars, planets - everything leaving Earth.

A 2D stretched helix forms on the screen.

ADITHYA

The Earth revolves around the sun, which revolves around the supermassive black hole in the center of the galaxy. We are seeing Earth right now from the scale of the Galaxy. So, what shape should we expect the Earth's trajectory to be?

ARYAN

In layman terms, a circular 3D helix.

ADITHYA

Slam it into two dimensions, what does it become?

RAHUL

(pretending indifference, pointing at the screen)

This. A 2D stretched helix.

Adithya doesn't react. He simply waits.

Aryan catches on immediately.

ARYAN

(mock serious, straightening up)

A stretched 2D helix, Professor!

ADITHYA

(grinning, milking the moment)

Excellent, my boy! Excellent!

Rahul's exhausted features push away because of the anger building up.

RAHUL

(snorts, bitter)

Oh yeah? Why are we slamming them into 2D, huh?

No reaction. Adithya places a hand behind his ear, acting as if to amplify his hearing.

ADITHYA

(looking at Aryan)

Did you hear a stupid ratsqueal?

ARYAN

(smirking)

No. But could you explain the reason for slamming into 2D, Professor?

ADITHYA

(faking irritation)

Theseratskeep showing up everywhere.

(taking a long breath)

Anyway, the slamming? Well, if you read the first topic on multiverse theory, it says, all parallel universes exist in either different configurations of dimensions or in more or less dimensions...

RAHUL

(dismissive, interrupting)

Blah, blah, blah...

(voice rising)

Why- Why does it even matter? Why does any of this matter?

ADITHYA

(without thinking, snapping back)

Why does it matter, huh? If it doesn't matter, why are you half-dead working on it.

(voice raising)

If it didn't matter, you should've just let the task go to trash after-

He stops.Too late.

Rahul lashes out at Adithya, pushing him in his chair, failing in efficiency due to Aryan being between them.

RAHUL

(infuriated)

After what? After my dad died?

(snorts furiously)

Had you not come up with thisstupididea, he wouldn't have, you, piece ofshit.

Rahul stand up. His exhaustion is visible, but it's now replaced with anger. Pure anger.

Adithya stands. Not backing down.

Aryan sighs, shrugging at their impulsive behavior.

ADITHYA

(not relaxing one bit)

If it was so stupid, why bother? Why didn't you just go home that evening?

(something striking in his head)

Why didn't you pick up his call that day?

Rahul breaks. His mind shatters. He tightens his hand into a fist, and moves it right towards him.

Adithya doesn't even flinch, ready to take it head on.

Just as it's about to hit, Rahul's hand is grabbed by Sunil standing right next to the two.

Aryan simply puts his hand in his pockets, and begins walking out of the room, thinking the breakdown is over.

ARYAN

(casual, glancing back from the door)

Cool. That's done. And not much to take from the simulation either. Time to go home, you two.

No reply. Their eyes are still locked.

ADITHYA

(not even glancing at Sunil, voice low, biting his anger)

I can take his punches. Let the dog bark.

No one else in the room even looks up. Not the students. Not the lab manager. Just another normal night in college.

Sunil studies Adithya's face—the fire in his eyes. Then, he lets go of Rahul's hand. But he doesn't step far. Just enough to act if things go south.

Rahul swings—a sharp, angry hit straight to Adithya's gut. He doesn't flinch. Doesn't even try to block. Just takes it.

ADITHYA

(shaking off the pain, voice sharp)

Sleepless nights and coffee cups don't make even dogs strong, informative.

Rahul exhales sharply. Too tired to snap back. Too drained to feel victorious. His anger had given him strength—now, even that is gone.

He swings again. Weaker. And again. Slower. One last time—it barely lands.

Then, his body gives up. His legs buckle. He slumps. Crashes forward.

Adithya catches him before his face smashes onto the ground. Sunil moves in, steadying him.

RAHUL

(muttering, barely conscious, words slurring together)

S-So-Sorr—

His voice fades. Unfinished. His eyelids flutter once—then shut.

FADE OUT.

**INT. BEDROOM, L-2, 18, NOIDA, UTTAR PRADESH - LATE EVENING
-APRIL 29 (A DAY LATER)**

A modest room. Walls, newly painted. A single bed in one corner of the room. A small table right next to it, a sheet of paper on it.

Rahul is asleep. He has been so, for the past 24 hours. The doctor had asked to let him be, as he needed his sleep much more than his meals right now.

He stirs in his sleep, groans. And his eyes open. For a few minutes, he can barely move. He forces himself upright, muscles aching. It

takes him a while to recognize it as his parents' home.

He remembers losing his balance in the lab. It hurts.

He notices a sheet of paper on the table, and opens it. It's a letter. Or rather a quickly scrawled out notice.

In messy small handwriting is written:

The doctor said to knock you down with punches if you ever half-die like that.

We got some great news from NASA. Looks like we're going to America. Yay!

So, get better fast.

Text me when you get better.

The guy who knocked some sense into you,

Adithya.

Oh, I almost forgot. Eliza dropped by here. That your girlfriend from college?

Rahul chuckles. Just as he picks up his phone to text him, his mother comes in, having heard voices from the bedroom.

As soon as she sees her son awake, a relief is exposed on her features. She paces fast to the bed, sitting down on the edge and hugs her son, her hold on him ever more harder.

RAHUL'S MOTHER

You're not going to that stinky apartment ever again. That sweet kid told me everything.

Rahul leans in, finding all the stress having eaten him up and swallowed him down. His mother's hug, he felt, could melt it away, probably.

RAHUL

(starving)

So, mum? How long's it been?

RAHUL'S MOTHER

So long. Almost three years since you'd gone to that place.

RAHUL

(stomach grumbling)

I was talking about how long I have been asleep. I am starving.

RAHUL'S MOTHER

(flustered)

Oh. That? Almost a day. Those kids were here the whole night yesterday. Went to school right from here this morning.

She walks offscreen to the kitchen.

Meanwhile, Rahul texts to Aryan and Adithya that he is up and kicking. Not really.

She comes back, with a plate.

RAHUL

(notices the meal)

I am starving for three days, and you're feeding me khichdi? Seriously?

RAHUL'S MOTHER

The doctor said to start with something light.

As his mother feeds him the first spoon, his eyes accidentally fall on the picture of his dad, on his then study table, back when he used to live here. His eyes fall.

RAHUL

(broken, calm)

I am sorry, mom. I am sorry for not being here when he-

His mother's eyes tear up. Before he is about to finish, she hugs him again, placing the bowl on the side-table.

RAHUL'S MOTHER

I'm just glad you're safe, son.

(beat, voice-breaking)

Seeing you like that – right after your dad left me forever—

Few minutes pass in embrace.

The bell rings.

RAHUL

(annoyed at being interrupted)

Who's it now?

Rahul's mother hands the food to him, as she rises to walk offscreen to open the house door.

RAHUL'S MOTHER (O.S.)

Hey, it's your little friends.

(teasing tone)

And Eliza.

RAHUL

(sighs, muttering under his breath)

Eliza? What was she doing with them?

(rolling his eyes)

They're not my little friends. They're my... Uhm, science partners.

He barely pauses as his room door is barged open, and Eliza (21, Australian, 5'6'', athletic figure) storms in, and paces right towards where Rahul's sitting.

A slap. Soft, but hard enough.

ELIZA

What in the world were you thinking? You could have-

(stops, panting)

You piece of-

Eliza grabs his shirt collar, locking her eyes to his, pulling him up close in anger as if she is about to head-butt him.

ELIZA

(gritting her teeth, barely restraining herself)

Cow. Freaking. Shit.

RAHUL

(chuckling to avoid more anger)

Hmm... Are we skipping straight to domestic violence, or do I at least get a hello first?

ARYAN

(grabbing the attention)

This isn't Australia. We don't kiss in our parents' home here.

Eliza blinks, exhales sharply, stepping back like she just realized something.

The two turn to find Aryan perched on the study table, and Adithya straddling the study chair, arms draped over the backrest.

ADITHYA

(muttering loud)

Remind me to keep the camera rolling the next time.

(matter-of-factly)

Anyhow, India isn't exactly fair to men filing domestic violence cases.

ARYAN

(looking at Adithya)

I think we shouldn't have said anything. It was quite a free cinema.

Rahul and Eliza blush a little, but Eliza hides away her redness in an instant, Rahul's a little lingering as Eliza settles down into the wooden chair next to the bed, quite closer to Rahul than the other two.

ARYAN

(rolling his eyes at the lost spectacle)

So, if you two love-birds are done, we've a little NASA talk to do.

Adithya turns on the PC on the study table, after sitting properly on the chair, booting it on as he begins signing in with his Google account.

ADITHYA

(mumbling)

I didn't expect a computer wiz to keep his computer without a password.

RAHUL

(to Adithya)

Oh, I don't use it nowadays. I used it back when I was 14.

(to Aryan)

NASA first. And for the record, Eliza and I aren't a thing.

ARYAN

(dry chuckle)

Yeah,likewe have buttons for our eyes.

(waving it off)

Anyhow, NASA wants us in America in about a month.

Adithya pulls up the e-mail on the computer.

ADITHYA

(turning back from the PC to look at Rahul)

We posted them their mistake on the given mail. The next day, I woke up to find a mail from the official NASA mail, saying they want us to verify our mail by our identity, saying they couldn't find ours in any scientific directory.

ARYAN

(taking on from there)

And we did that, we had to borrow your Aadhar Card as well, and they were shocked, and asked us if we could come to America to help them solve the crisis.

RAHUL

(flabbergasted)

They want all three of us in America. Freaking hell, wow... What did you say?

ADITHYA

(teasing, trying to keep Rahul on the edge)

We told them that we can't come because we have school.

Rahul is beyond shocked.

RAHUL

You've got to be kidding me? If NASA calls, you go. That's how it works.

ADITHYA

(shaking his head)

I was kidding, of course. I told them we couldn't say for sure, but we wouldn't be able to pay for visa and the flight anyhow.

RAHUL

(riding in a swing of emotions)

So? Then?

ELIZA

(finally catching on a little)

Then what, that's what loans are for?

ARYAN

(giving her a sarcastic glare)

Well, we outright denied them that if we had to pay for both the visa and the flight, we'd rather not come.

ELIZA

(deadpan)

That's so dumb!

RAHUL

(knowing they're only building up the suspense)

Let 'em cook, Eliza.

ADITHYA

(laughs)

They said they'd cover every expense of the journey. They even offered a 5-star hotel stay. Seems like NASA's desperate.

Saying Rahul is excited, is an understatement. He stuffs his mouth with thekhichdi.

RAHUL

(between stuffing)

So, when are we leaving?

ARYAN

(smirking at the excitement)

Actually, I was thinking going on-

ELIZA

(giving him a glare)

No time soon. You better stuff yourself up, before you even think of getting out of this house.

RAHUL

(trying to ignore Eliza, playful, as if only Aryan can hear him)

Don't worry. Who does she think she is -my mom?

Just as Eliza is about to throw a fit, Rahul's mother enters. Only Adithya notices.

ADITHYA

(enjoying the banter)

Well, there is your mom.

RAHUL'S MOTHER

(having overheard the conversation, giggling)

Yup, I am your mom. So, you are going to hear what sweet Eliza just said.

ADITHYA

(thrilled)

So, two weeks time. Either you stuff yourself enough that Eliza lets you go or we're going ourselves.

Aryan gets down from the table, Adithya rises from the chair. They walk offscreen, taking away Rahul's mother from the room.

ARYAN (O.S.)

(smirking)

We should let the two love-birds some time. You two better not do some of that thing.

ADITHYA

(enjoying the tension)

Kissing not allowed as well.

The sound of Eliza's chair creeping a little more closer to the bed, as the two laugh at each other's antics.

FADE TO BLACK.

**EXT. FRIDAY MARKET, BADARPUR, NEW DELHI - EARLY EVENING -MAY 11
(TWELVE DAYS LATER)**

Shops. All on the road. None legal. Here today. Gone tomorrow. The crowd is alive. Loud. A cheap market for the locals, for the middle class.

Who buys local goods? Better to grab something cheap, wear it for a few months, toss it. No point dragging expensive things around all year.

Clothes—for men, for women, for children. Toys. Fast food. Shoes. They say if you look hard enough, you'll find anything you're looking for.

Not exactly looking for anything, Adithya finds what he didn't know he was searching for.

Who he didn't expect to find. Sakshi.

It's hard to describe what really happens in that moment—when he sees her alone - shopping.

If you could even call it shopping. It was more like scavenging.

And just like that, the chaos of the market fades. The noise, the colors, the motion—none of it matters. She is the only stillness in the storm

His self splits. Not a new occurrence. Ever since the trauma of brotherhood, it had become routine.

The voices only he hears.

HEART

(gentle, hopeful)

She's right there. Go talk. It's worth a shot.

MIND

(cold, rational)

She's right there. Go away. It's not even worth a shot.

His feet refuse to move. His hands? Useless. Just as he debates running – Sakshi waves.

His feet stay rooted for half a second longer than they should. His mind screams at him to walk away. But she waved. And that was enough.

ADITHYA

(muttering to himself)

Guess you're winning, Heart!

He waves back. Crosses the road.

Hands in pockets. Indifferent. Or pretending to be.

ADITHYA

(in his mind-scape, to Mind and Heart)

I want you two to stay quiet. This talk is not going to be about failed romance, understood? All I have to do is tell her I am going to America tomorrow.

In his eerie mindscape, he sees the two nod, and reaches up to Sakshi.

He's barely taller than her - 5'7" over 5'5". His eyes lock with hers for a second. Too long. He looks away, scanning the crowd as if the neon-lit carts were the most interesting thing in the world.

SAKSHI

(gorgeous smile)

Didn't expect a genius roaming on the streets. That too, this crowd of all places.

He exhales, forcing himself to stay in the moment. He's not here to get sentimental. Just talk. Just tell her and leave. Just be the you that only saw her as a friend long back.

That switch had always been easy for him. To mask away himself. But today, for some reason, it takes a second longer.

ADITHYA

(chuckles, scratching his head)

Well, I didn't think I'd find your majesty here, either.

He puts his hand back in his pockets, his nervousness suppressed under his laid-back attitude.

Sakshi laughs back at being called 'majesty'. She nudges her fist forward.

He pulls out his right hand from his pocket. A fist bump. Their smiles show how it had all started. Their first meeting, and the iconic bump.

For a split second, nothing has changed. They're still the same two kids from back then. But the moment passes, and reality sets in.

The fist bump had been a little something Adithya had introduced to her. Their little secret.

SAKSHI

(still chuckling at the comment)

I didn't become the head-girl and I am already getting the honor.

(genuine smile)

That's reassuring.

ADITHYA

(light-hearted)

Yeah, as if I am any genius. Just a guy who got interested and worked alittlehard.

SAKSHI

(walking next to him through the crowd, keeping a distance)

I don't think you're that humble with others. Some in my class go so far as to call you arrogant.

ADITHYA

(looking around at the shops)

Bitharsh, don't you think? But I guess I have trained for that, being friends with Aryan.

SAKSHI

(playfully scoffs at the name)

You know... I should have shut Aryan up that day. That 'slave' comment? Such a shitty thing to say.

(a clear vein popping on her forehead)

I'd have killed that idiot, if that were outside school.

ADITHYA

(laughing a little loud)

He's five inches taller than you. He'd absolutely tower over you.

SAKSHI

(tilting her head, pretending to think)

Or maybe just rough him up a little? Push him into a trash can?

(scoffs, waves it off)

I mean, we don't actually have to kill him.

(taking her words back a little)

But we do have the upper hand... Together we're about 11 feet.

ADITHYA

(enjoying himself)

Hey, aren't you assuming something here... He's also my friend.

SAKSHI

(scoffs)

So, what? You should be on my side, cuz this is for your insult...

A call ringtone blazes from Adithya's pockets as he pulls out his phone.

ADITHYA

(sighs, exhales)

Speak of the devil, it's him.

SAKSHI

(just as he's about to pick up the call)

Ooh, let me answer – bet he won't see it coming.

Adithya hands her the call, knowing Aryan barely touches the love topic on calls, assured that this is probably about tomorrow's flight.

Sakshi picks up the call. Puts the phone against her ear, after hurrying him to a place with less crowd.

ARYAN

(over the phone)

So, all set for tomorrow, dude?

Sakshi places a finger on Adithya's lips to gesture him to stay quiet.

She keeps a dead-serious expression, waiting just long enough for Aryan to be confused

SAKSHI

(imitating a rowdy tone)

Your boy's been kidnapped. If you want him back, wire fifty thousand cash to his account.

ARYAN

(mocking, playing along)

Fifty thousand? Oh damn, I don't think I have that much lying around.

(rolling his eyes)

Hell with it, as if I'd ever believe that. No kidnapper waits someone to call the kidnapped.

(pauses, then deadpan)

It's that witch, isn't it, Iyer?

(pause again, calm voice)

I know you're there.

Adithya tries to open his mouth to speak, but is immediately shushed by Sakshi.

SAKSHI

(over the phone, the rowdy tone vanishing)

Don't interruptus, okay? I am trying to have a decent conversation with my friend.

ARYAN

(louder)

Tell you what, witch, he's my friend as well.

SAKSHI

(smirk)

If that's how you wanna play this, show up outside the Friday Market, we will see.

Before Aryan protests, she hangs up...

ADITHYA

(rolling his eyes)

Was that necessary, Miss Kidnapper?

Sakshi chuckles. Hands back his phone.

The phone rings. Aryan.

SAKSHI

(snorts playfully)

Decline it. Let that idiot come.

ADITHYA

(sighing)

I swear, you two should just fight in a boxing ring and get it over with.

Adithya declines the call.

SAKSHI

(smiles, imagining)

If that ever happens, you're entering the ring with me, I need that 11 feet height.

ADITHYA

(mock offended)

Oh great, I'm just a human ladder to you now?

Sakshi just grins.

There is a slight pause. A silence perhaps. Nothing too wild. Just too people looking for what to talk.

SAKSHI

Let's go get something to eat.

ADITHYA

(not having any better ideas)

Sure. A burger? And what about Aryan? He's coming here for the fight, isn't he?

SAKSHI

(malicious smile)

Who cares? Let him be lost for a while. He'd call anyhow.

The two start walking towards the shop which is quite famous for its burgers. It's a little far from the main market but the burgers are worth the walk.

Adithya takes the side towards the road, letting her walk near the footpath.

Sakshi doesn't say anything, but there's a flicker of a glance. A silent acknowledgment? Maybe. Maybe not.

MIND

(in the mindscape)

See, folks! Gentleman of the twenty-first century.

ADITHYA

(to Mind in mindscape)

You got some problem?

HEART

(happy)

Ignore the rude freak, Adi. Keep up the talk.

Both Adithya and Sakshi look around here and there for something to talk, continuing to walk.

ADITHYA

(distant eyes)

Things still rough in school? You know...

She exhales, gaze dropping for half a second before forcing a small smile.

SAKSHI

Yeah... I am still alone pushing for an election for Head Girl.

ADITHYA

(understanding)

It'll work out, don't worry... And if it doesn't, you're already Head Girl for me.

SAKSHI

(shakes her head, pouts)

Yeah, and you hardly come to school. So, it barely makes a difference.

ADITHYA

(defensive)

That's not true-

SAKSHI

(playfully snapping back)

Oh, when was the last time you came to school?

ADITHYA

(counting)

About two weeks ago, I think...

SAKSHI

(eying him)

Still want to justify?

He exhales, raising his hands in fake surrender.

ADITHYA

(grumbling)

Okay, okay, point taken. I'm aghoststudent.

They reach the burger shop. A cart - crowded. It may not really be the best location for a burger shop, but the cleanliness - Adithya has checked it many times himself - is much better than the rest of the shops nearby.

Adithya goes up and stands amongst the crowd, waiting for his turn.

Sakshi rolls her eyes at his need for proper turns, and grabs his hand, taking him away from the crowd.

SAKSHI

(walking around the crowd to the back path, still holding onto his hand)

We won't get a burger in our whole lives if we stood in the crowd.

ADITHYA

Oh, yeah, so where are you taking me then?

Turning around and seeing the back path, they both find it blocked. Beneath the blocking is some sort of barrel.

SAKSHI

(turning to Adithya)

Get up on it, and ask him to give you the burger.

ADITHYA

(shakes her head)

We could've easily gotten the burger the normal way.

SAKSHI

(sighs)

Just do it, will you?

He climbs onto the barrel, and sees at the other side, having a back view of the vendor's cart.

ADITHYA

One burger, please.

SAKSHI

(grumbling)

Ask two... Aren't you gonna eat.

He ignores her. The shopkeeper hands him one.

ADITHYA

Now, make another, with nothing but the bun, thetikki, and thechatni.

SAKSHI

(groaning)

Oh, how can you even call that burger then?

The shopkeeper gets a little annoyed but hands it to Adithya anyhow.

Adithya bends down to hand her the burger, so as to get down from the barrel.

ADITHYA

(handing her the burgers)

Hold mine as well, will ya?

He takes out thirty rupees from his pockets and hands it to the shopkeeper from above the barrel.

He jumps down, and takes back the minimalist burger from her hand.

She eyes his burger like it personally offended her. A long, judging stare.

SAKSHI

(deadpan)

You call that a burger?

He looks back at her, confused for a moment, as this is his usual.

He blinks at her, then looks at his burger, genuinely confused about what's wrong with it.

ADITHYA

(finally realizing)

Oh, this? I don't like vegies in my burger.

Just as they get out of the crowded shop, Sakshi's phone starts ringing from inside her jeans pocket.

Adithya extends his hand for her to give her burger so that she can take out the phone.

She declines the call.

ADITHYA

Who is it? Your dad?

SAKSHI

(fake smile)

I'd not have declined if it were him.

ADITHYA

(hands her the burger)

So?

He takes a big delicious bite of his burger.

SAKSHI

(slight disappointment)

Remember Varun?

(pause)

He asked me out yesterday.

The warm soft burger suddenly feels hard and cold in Adithya's mouth.

ADITHYA

(swallowing hard, almost choking)

And?

SAKSHI

(smiles weakly)

I think you know what I did already.

ADITHYA

(pursing his lips)

You said you weren't interested.

She exhales softly, gaze lowered. Then, a quiet nod as he takes a small bite of her burger.

MIND

(empathizing but cold)

See, this is your future if you ever pull up your guts. And if you don't, expect just this friendship.

ADITHYA

(in mind-space)

Can you shut up? Right now is not about me, it's about her.

She looks at him, her eyes filled, but keeping the tears in. Her eyes reflect more emotions now than Adithya had ever seen in them.

SAKSHI

(exhales, cracked voice)

All I ever wanted was... Uhm... Was friends.

Adithya simply kept quiet, letting her go on, letting her continue, his face masking away all emotions, as his eyes locked into hers.

SAKSHI

(exhales harder)

Is that too much to ask for? Why can't I be just friends with boys? Why do they have to come around the next week, and seek me like I am some prize for a week-long marathon.

(pauses, wipes off her eye)

And girls? Those spiteful bitc-

(stops herself from saying the word, sighs again)

They spread so many rumors just because I am popular amongst the boys.

She clenches her jaw, staring into the distance for a moment, then looks back at him.

SAKSHI

(soft, but exhausted)

Why?

He exhales, eyes narrowing slightly. He could lie. He could comfort her. Instead, he chooses the truth.

ADITHYA

(calm, empathetic, emotionless tone)

Because you're a rare blend of attractiveness and beauty.

SAKSHI

(dry chuckle)

So... Beautiful people don't deserve friends?

ADITHYA

(biting back his emotions)

They do. Perhaps, the way of searching differs.

SAKSHI

(genuinely interested, breaking voice)

That is?

ADITHYA

(exhales)

I don't know. I am usually on the other side of the beauty line.

A faint bitterness creeps in his voice. He doesn't say more. He doesn't need to. Adithya's fist clenches.

ADITHYA

(his poetic sense taking him over)

But I have heard someone say, "Don't look for friends when talking to someone. Just talk. Just be who you are."

She stays quiet for a moment. Maybe thinking. Maybe not wanting to think.

SAKSHI

(dry)

Sounds like a poet.

ADITHYA

(smiling weakly)

That someone also exclaimed, "Romantic love is just the next level of friendship. Because it is friends who know the most of who you are."

Sakshi takes in the word, letting them sink in, as she chuckles slightly, having finished her burger, finding it ironic to the modern world, which treats friend-zoning to the opposite of romance.

Not knowing she is doing the same thing as well.

Maybe even ignoring.

SAKSHI

(laughs a little)

You made those words just now, didn't you?

ADITHYA

(scratching his head)

Yeah. But I really mean them.

SAKSHI

(weak smile)

You think I am not myself when talking to others?

Adithya sighs, taking in her question, and building upon his answer.

ADITHYA

(handing her his handkerchief to wipe away the tears properly)

Yeah. I think you limit yourself, you move, you talk, you study, all of it as if you're some role model. You're angry? Let it out in some manner.

(beat)

You're sad? Let it show. Who cares what others think?

SAKSHI

(genuinely doubting)

You think the guys who approach me after that would like me to be just friends?

ADITHYA

(sighing, thinking)

Not necessarily-

SAKSHI

(cutting him off)

Then, what's the use?

ADITHYA

That's why I said the second line. This world in its info-dumping has spread the lies that relationships break friendships.

(deep breath)

If it's not friends who one gets in a relationship with, what's the problem with arranged marriages?

(looking around)

You have fallen prey to that dumping...

She looks away, gripping the handkerchief tightly. But she doesn't answer.

The silence stretches between them. For a second, he wonders if she'll argue. But she doesn't.

ADITHYA

(brutal honesty)

If you wanna live by what the mainstream has to say, so be it. But this is your life, not theirs.

Sakshi looks at him. He seems different from the last moment. A glow, perhaps. But she brushes the thought away.

Having finished his monologue, Adithya feels vulnerable. As if he had been using those words to cover himself up. He fiddles with his fingers.

ADITHYA

(confused on how she took his words)

Sorry. I think I got carried away.

She watches him fidget, debating whether to call him out for it. But she doesn't.

The two suddenly notice a mad 6 foot (5'11" actually) giant stomping towards them as the two brush off their emotions, masking it away from their faces.

Aryan finally reaches the two, and first smacks Adithya in the head.

ARYAN

(furious, to Adithya)

You dawg! Phone on silent, ignoring my calls? I swear, I'm killing you later.

He exhales sharply, turning to Sakshi like a prosecutor shifting to his next suspect. Adjusts his sleeves like he's about to deliver a closing argument in court.

ARYAN

(turning to Sakshi)

You witch! First you call me like a kidnapper and then, challenge me to come to the place. And then, leave away.

He exhales again, turning back to Adithya like a robot.

ARYAN

Your dad called you ten times. And your mother fifteen. Be ready for the whipping of your life.

Adithya pulls out his phone and checks, thinking he's dead. To his surprise, the only calls were from Aryan and he rolls his eyes.

ADITHYA

(unfiltered)

You just had to try to make me piss my pants.

SAKSHI

(disgust)

Ew. Really, that's how you guys talk? Disgusting.

They exchange a slow, dramatic look – then turn to her in perfect sync.

ARYAN AND ADITHYA

(together)

Forgive us, oh dignified one.

All of them laugh together at the moment. Like crazy madmen. In this case, madwoman as well.

Calm silence. Nothing awkward. Just pure serenity.

ARYAN

Told her about tomorrow?

SAKSHI

Told what?

ADITHYA

No. Not yet.

ARYAN

(shakes his head)

When are you telling? After reaching America.

SAKSHI

Wai- Wait, what now? You guys are going America?

ARYAN

(knowing how tense it's going to get)

Oh... Boy...

ADITHYA

(hesitates)

Uhm. Yeah. We're going to America.

Sakshi breaths. Processes. Breaths again. Processes.

SAKSHI

(flat, dangerously calm)

...What?

ARYAN

(seeing the storm brewing)

Oh... Boy...

(whispering to Adithya)

Consider yourself dead.

Sakshi looks at Aryan for a second. Turns to Adithya. Then, back at Aryan.

SAKSHI

(venom in her tongue)

Smack him hard, will you?

Aryan is not one to listen to others. But he doesn't argue when it comes to getting a good hit on his best-friend.

Aryan shrugs, as if to say "Fair enough" – then swings.

Smack.

SAKSHI

(turns to Adithya)

So, let's make this clear, shall we?

(exhales sharply)

So, all that time you were trying to small-talk, you never thought of going along with 'You are going to America'.

Adithya lost whatever he used to have when he argued the complexities of the universe, and the inexistence of a dietic figure.

He considers running. No. That won't work. He considers reasoning. No. That's worse. He accepts fate.

ADITHYA

(trying to delay the inevitable)

Yeah... That sounds about right.

SAKSHI

(not even looking at Aryan this time)

Smack him. Again. Don't hesitate.

Aryan blinks. Then nods, as if accepting his divine duty.

SMACK.

Adithya gives Aryan a glare - "I'll kill you later."

ADITHYA

(rubbing his head to ease the pain)

That's brutal enough, Sakshi.

Sakshi narrows her eyes at Adithya, not willing to take such a statement as a point to back down.

She stares at him. The silence stretches. Then—

SAKSHI

(flat, unwavering)

Don't stop, one more.

This time, Aryan doesn't shrug. Doesn't hesitate.

SMACK.

ADITHYA

(having had enough)

Enough is enough.

He exhales sharply, rubbing his temples, then looks at her—dead serious.

ADITHYA

(narrowing eyes back at Sakshi)

I could, you know, call you by that name if Sakshi isn't good enough for you to stop, lo-

Her shoulders stiffen. Eyes widen. A flicker of real fear — then she snaps.

SAKSHI

(alarmed)

Don't you dare-

ARYAN

(whispering)

Say it... You're not a slave.

SAKSHI

(sighs, finally giving in)

Okay, okay... No more smacks...

Adithya and Sakshi finally relax - both for different reasons.

Aryan is annoyed; he was hoping the name was revealed and Adithya would be smacked even more - fun.

ADITHYA

(to Sakshi)

Come on, let's drop you home.

SAKSHI

(defensive snort)

I can go home myself.

ADITHYA

(matter-of-factly)

Everyone can do that. Why say with a snort? I was just offering you company.

She blinks, processing. Then, a small shrug – like she never resisted in the first place.

SAKSHI

(flustered)

Oh... Okay... Sure.

ARYAN

(having had enough fun)

Go drop her yourself, slave. I have to work on my oscillator.

Aryan begins to walk away, deciding to give Adithya the time of his life with Sakshi. Who knows when he'll get it next time?

Sakshi watches him walk away, considering. Then – smack.

SAKSHI

(grinning with satisfaction)

Call him that again, and you'll get it harder.

Aryan merely rolls his eyes, not really in the mood to pick another fight. He continues walking away.

ARYAN

(raising his hand, gesturing bye)

See ya.

Adithya looks at her, and then, looks at the far-away Aryan.

ADITHYA

(smirking)

It was not like you had to do that.

SAKSHI

(knuckling her fingers like an amateur)

Oh, my hands were itching. Besides-

She pauses, letting the words linger, as she turns to him.

SAKSHI

(innocent smile)

A wise man told me today to act like myself.

He stares at her, realizing he has no counter.

ADITHYA

(rolling his eyes)

Yeah, a really wiseman!

The two talked and talked. Until they reached her place. The world? It hardly seemed noisy. Time? It was slowing down.

She had him take the fifteen rupees for her burger, despite his protesting.

Had something changed that day? In Adithya's terms, no one knows. For Sakshi, God knows.

He lingers on the door for a second. Then, with a small nod – to himself more than to her – he turns and walks away before her parents came to open the door.

Someday, yes. Not today. It was too early. Too early to meet them.

FADE OUT.